

PHILOSOPHICAL MAGIC

Hermeticism, divinity, and the universe



▲ Master theorist

Hermes Trismegistus (center) is depicted on the floor of Siena Cathedral. The supposed creator of the *Corpus Hermeticum*, he is described here as a contemporary of Moses.

Hermeticism (or Hermetism) refers to a set of philosophical and theological ideas that were much discussed in Renaissance Europe. One important idea centered on the belief in a spirit that unified the universe and everything in it. A human being was a microcosm (miniature) of the universe, which was the macrocosm (the whole of the complex system).

New ways with old ideas

Many Renaissance ideas now labeled Hermetic were in fact Platonic, and came from the ancient Athenian philosopher Plato via Roman scholar

Plotinus, who developed a concept of a oneness underpinning the universe in the 3rd century CE. A key work of the Hermetic tradition was the *Corpus Hermeticum*, a selection of Byzantine texts that explored the mystical nature of divinity and the universe, and how this related to humankind. All these ideas were rediscovered in 15th-century Florence. Around 1460 the scholar Marsilio Ficino began translating a Greek version of the *Corpus* into Latin. His 1471 translation included two treatises: the *Asclepius*, containing material about ritual magic, and the *Poimandres*, which included passages on astronomy-cosmology.

The *Corpus Hermeticum* takes the form of dialogues between young men and the legendary figure Hermes Trismegistus, which literally means “thrice-greatest Hermes”. He was often seen as a conflation of two pagan gods—the Egyptian Thoth (see p.25) and the Greek Hermes. The *Corpus*

Hermeticum was reputed to have been written by Hermes Trismegistus and to be ancient Egyptian wisdom that had been passed on to the Old Testament prophet Moses and Plato.

Scientific advances

Certain practical implications of Hermeticism, such as putting nature to the test through experiments, appealed to many intellectuals interested in science in the Renaissance. Their exciting new ideas about how the universe worked became entwined with magic. Radical Italian philosophers, including Giordano Bruno (see panel, below) and Giovanni Pico della Mirandola, melded Hermeticism with

GIORDANO BRUNO (1548–1600)

Free thinker

One radical who responded to Hermetic precepts was the controversial Italian philosopher and occultist Giordano Bruno. He wrote various essays on magic, stating that “Magicians can do more by means of faith than physicians by the truth.” His ideas often involved natural magic, such as the natural attractions and repulsions between things, and sought new truths about the forces of existence. Bruno’s concept of an endless universe and universal soul included notions that many felt were occult and blasphemous, such as implying Christ’s miracles were simply clever conjuring. In 1600, the Italian authorities executed him on charges of heretical beliefs.



This bronze statue was built in 1889 on the site of Giordano’s execution in Campo de’ Fiori, Rome.

“How many bodies have we to pass through ... before we hasten to the One alone?”

CORPUS HERMETICUM